Natural Heritage

Botany

The site has some of the world's most endangered medicinal plant species such as the Anselia Africana (Palamela) which is listed in the world red data list. Some of the medicinal plants found in the site are Adenica Glauca (monnagaapare). PLIZ INSERT A PICTURE OF THIS PLANT. The area is also rich with edible wild fruits that are highly nutritious such as baobab fruits, wild berries, mogwagwa, mogwagwa, mogomphatla and many others.

Geology

Several streams were observed along the elongated Tswapong formation, trending northwest direction from the hill top. Observations on the outcrop show that there is displacement of blocks on the northern side and this together with a network of streams flowing from the hilltop indicate that the formation has been intensively faulted, hence water follows along faults lines resulting with numerous gorges in the area. Gorges such as Photophoto and Motetane are the result of water flowing through normal fault before reaching hard resistant quartzite rock resulting as water falls. The geology of the area has significant influence on the occupants of Old Palapye since they relied on geological feature as their cultural and tradition materials. Old Palapye is situated in an intensely faulted area with lot of streams and gorges that could have provided water for residents especially that they are perennial sources of water for the current occupants's livestock. Shear zones also provided quartzite and sandstone slabs for shelter construction. The foundation of the church was constructed using quartzite blocks found in the vicinity together with shale slabs believed to be from Lotsane Shale Formation.

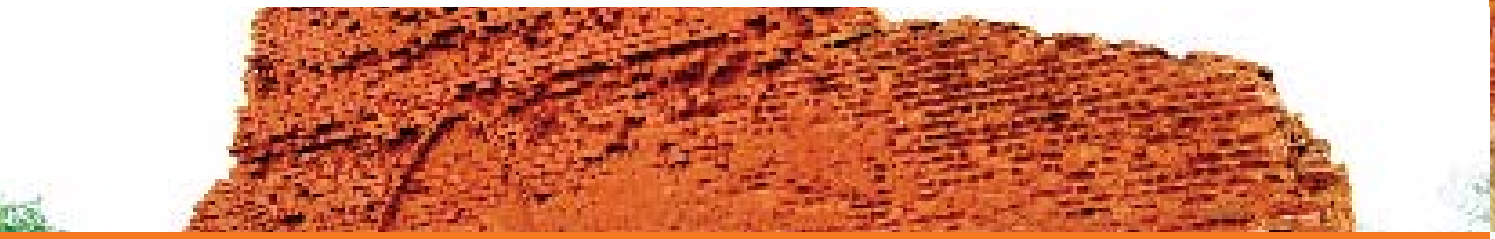
Some Rules

Old Palapye is a National Monument administered by the Botswana National Museum and protected by the revised Monuments and Relics Act (2001). Adherence to some basic guidelines will make your visit worthwhile and ensure the continued protection of a part of Botswana's unique heritage:

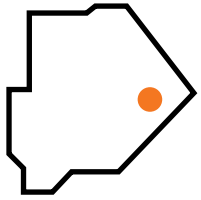
- Use the designated parking lot
- Report to the Field Assistants' office and complete the visitors' book.
- Please do not interfere with the Paintings, Engravings, Stonewalls or any other feature.
- Do not remove any artifacts.
- Cooperate with the Field Assistants.
- Take away all your litter with you.

PLEASE NOTE:

Researchers and commercial photographers, contact the National Museum for more information.







Designation:
Natural & Cultural
Area: approx. 3km²
Adoption priorities:
interpretation centre, field assistants, signage, trails

For further information, contact:
The Archaeology Division, Botswana National Museum
Private Bag 00114 Gaborone, Botswana
Phone: +267 3974616 Fax: +267 3911186 / 3902797

OLD PALAPYE

BOTSWANA national museum

ADOPT A MONUMENT
GIVING LIFE TO BOTSWANA'S HERITAGE SITES

PA201511

Natural heritage site **Cultural Heritage Site**

OLD **PALAPYE**

Old Palapye monument is located in geographical position 23˚ 37’ 30’South and 27˚17 20” East. It is a multicultural material site with relics from Middle Stone Age, Late Stone Age, Early Iron Age, up to 19th Century remains of Ngwato Capital, Old Palapye. It is part of the Tswapong Cultural Landscape,and is protected under the Monuments and Relics Act 2001







Cultural Heritage of the Bangwato capital from 1889 to 1902

Palatswe (more commonly known as Old Palapye) was inhabited by the Bangwato between 1889 and 1902 under the chieftainship of Khama III. Khama was a man of considerable vision and is regarded as the key figure behind the expansion of Bangwato power and authority from the late nineteenth century. He was also the first Bangwato chief to be converted to Christianity. Having come from Shoshong, Phalatswe was KhamaIII’s Bangwato capital for 13 years from 1889 until 1902 upon migration to Serowe. They found the Batswapong people living at Dikgopheng at the foot of the hills. At the time of settlement there were up to 30 000 people living at Phalatswe including resident European missionaries, wagon traders, hunters and adventures. The picturesque photophoto valley and its waterfalls was one of the initial attractions as it provided water for the inhabitants. The popular feature of the site is the burnt-bricks relics of the London Missionary Society (LMS) church, built between 1891 and 1894. However, the rest of the landscape is replete with piles or lines of stones, which are relics of the traditional wattle and daub houses together with granary bases and compound (lelwapa) walls of the Bangwato.



The site has remains of a prison, a market centre, European gravesite and African burials including that of Khama III’s wife (Mma Bessie), thousands of scatters of potsherds, porcelain and chips of aslcoholic bottles. The site is at the foot of the Tswapong hills and is replete with interpretations and stories attached to aspects of the hills by the local Batswapong people who believe and communicate with the Bapedi ancestral spirits known to be resident in the hills.

Although the focal point of the settlement was Khama’s kgotla, the LMS church, by virtue of its size and location about the rest of the settlement must have been a dominant feature of the landscape in both physical and symbolic terms. One final feature of interest is the occurrence of concentrations of graves. These took the form of low piles of stones covering individual graves. Previously, Bangwato and other Tswana speaking people either buried their dead in kraals, under malwapa or occasionally under piles of stones, usually in each individual case in association with specific houses. Whilst burial under piles of stones had been practiced previously, an interesting addition to such piles at Phalatswe is the placement of a large stone at the ends as a headstone.